ARTICLE PSALM 141:5 30 OCT 2026 NORM REED

Struck by Kindness

Nobody enjoys being corrected. We push back, we explain, and if the correction is public we remember it for years. I have done all three.

So it is worth stopping at a line in Psalm 141, where David asks for it.

> *Let a righteous man strike me – it is a kindness.*

The word is *hesed* – covenant loyalty, the thing God keeps whether or not it has been earned. David puts it on a blow. Not on the advice, not on the friendship, on the blow.

I want to persuade you that this is worth praying while you are young enough for it to shape how you lead.

What we were reading

For a number of years in Adelaide we hosted the Willow Creek Global Leadership Summit. Bill Hybels' books sat on our shelves alongside the Bible as key reading.

Today those books gather dust or sit in a storage closet.

You may not know the names. Willow Creek, Hillsong, Mars Hill – three of the most watched churches in the world, and the distance between how they were spoken of and how things turned out was very short. Smarter people than me have written on why.

These men were not short of righteous friends.

Credit and blame

Watch what happens to a good year.

The church grows, people are converted, the giving holds up. Ask any of us how it happened and we will say God did it, and we will mean it. But something else is going on underneath, and it is almost impossible to see while it is happening: the success attaches to us, and failure does not. A bad year has causes — the economy, the denomination, the people who left, the previous pastor. A good year has a leader.

Nobody says it. You only have to notice how differently the two arrive.

And in ministry there is a second layer, which is worse. A full church looks like a verdict. If God is visibly blessing what you are doing, then correction does not merely sting — it sounds like resistance to something God is blessing. The evidence really is there, and it is on your side.

That is the season in which a man is least able to hear, and it is the season in which everyone around him has the most reason to tell him he is right.

Search me

The obvious answer is to examine yourself.

David does that too. He asks God to search him and know his heart, and to see if there is any grievous way in him. It is the right prayer.

But Jeremiah says the heart is deceitful above all things, and if that is true, it is also true of the examination. The heart under suspicion is the one conducting the search. A man can pray *search me*, feel the better for having prayed it, and nothing has happened at all.

We live among disposable things and we have learnt to treat relationships the same way.

Which is why Psalm 141 does not stop at God.

David asks God to guard his mouth and keep watch over the door of his lips. Then, two verses later, he names a man.

That is the difference, and the whole weight of the psalm sits on it. A prayer made only to God can be quietly managed. An invitation extended to somebody who can walk into your office cannot.

The man he names

David does not ask for a wise man, or an experienced one, or an elder. He asks for a *tzaddiq*, a righteous man. The qualification is what he is, not what he knows and not what office he holds.

That is worth sitting with, because it rules out the thing we would naturally build. A committee can be appointed. Standing cannot.

And righteous does not mean unblemished. The man praying this psalm is David. The same man wrote Psalm 51, and that one has Nathan in the heading — a prophet walking in on a king who had arranged a killing to cover an adultery.

So the two psalms are one disposition. In 51 he is struck and does not refuse it. In 141 he asks for it in advance. He is called a man after God's own heart, and it was never because he did no wrong. It was that doing wrong never stopped him seeing God's kindness, and never stopped him wanting to be corrected.

Which means failure can make a man into exactly the friend you need. Often it doesn't. The difference is whether he received the correction, or only survived the exposure — and you can usually tell, because one of them produces a gentle man and the other produces a careful one.

Norm 2

Let me tell you about the best example I have known.

Norm Armstrong represented Oral Roberts in Australia in the 1960s and 70s. Then something went wrong. I do not know what, I never asked, and I never needed to know.

By the time I met him he was pastoring a church in Sydney. It was stable, it had an active missions vision, and it gave away a large percentage of its money to missions around the world. He came to Papua New Guinea, and we became friends despite the age difference. Norm 1 and Norm 2 — and he insisted on being Norm 2.

I cannot recall a critical word coming out of his mouth. When he spoke about other people, it was appreciative. He didn't correct. He loved.

My field director went to him for advice and listened to what he got. I do not know whether he ever asked Norm to strike him. I know he would

have taken it.

The heart under suspicion is the one conducting the search.

I have thought about that for a long time, and I think the two things are the same thing. It was the years of no criticism that made his word count. A man who corrects often is a man whose correction you can discount as his habit. Norm Armstrong had no habit to discount.

The other side of it

All of that is about receiving. But the psalm needs two men in it, and only one of them is praying.

Somebody has to be the friend.

That part does not depend on your age or your position, and it cannot be arranged at short notice. You cannot walk in on a man you have not been walking with. The relationship is built years before it is needed, in ordinary time, over things that do not matter.

We are not good at this. We live among disposable things and we have learnt to treat relationships the same way: useful while they are easy, replaced when they are not. *Hesed* is the opposite of that. It is the loyalty that holds when there is no longer any reason for it to hold.

Which tells you where the test falls. Not in saying the hard thing — plenty of men can say a hard thing. The test comes afterwards, when he takes it badly. If the friendship cools, or you withdraw, or you go quiet and wait to

be proved right, then what you offered was an opinion. Staying is the covenant part.

He didn't correct. He loved.

You will not know when it starts.

So the invitation is the safeguard. Not the self-examination, and not the structures — the invitation, made to a particular man, before you need it.

It will not feel like loyalty when it arrives. It will feel like someone has misunderstood you at the worst possible moment, and you will want to explain. That is what David is praying about when he asks that his head not refuse it. He expected to flinch too.

And here is what he calls it. Not wisdom, not accountability, not good counsel.

> *Let a righteous man strike me — it is hesed.*

The word for what God keeps when we have not kept anything. He puts it on the blow.

Find the man. Ask him while you are young.

This article did not begin with artificial intelligence. It began with years of ministry, reading, prayer, suffering, and conversation.

During its development, AI became a conversation partner. It challenged assumptions, tested arguments, suggested structures, and helped refine expression. Many of the words here emerged through that dialogue.

The experiences, convictions, interpretations, and conclusions remain my own.